NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠5

Board: 2
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 4
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♦9

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ Q J 4
♥ Q J 3
♦ K Q J 2
♣ A J 5

♠ K 9 7
♥ 8 7 6 4 2
♦ A 9
♣ 10 8 2



♠ A 10 8 5 3
♥ K 5
♦ 8 7 4 3
♣ 9 3

♠ 6 2
♥ A 10 9
♦ 10 6 5
♣ K Q 7 6 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠5

Partner's 2NT bid invites you to bid game if you have a maximum hand. You aren't thrilled by all the Quacks in your hand but with 17 points you bid 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♠5. West wins the first trick with the ♠K and returns the ♠9. East plays the ♠3 under your ♠J.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 5 :: Total = 7

You need 2 more tricks, and the ♦ suit will provide them after you drive out the ♦A.

Is that what you should do?

That is definitely **NOT** what you should do. East led the ♠5, then played the ♠3 to the second trick. You have seen the ♠4 and ♠2 so it is clear that East started with a 5-card suit. That means West still has a ♠. The instant you play a ♦ one of the defenders will grab the ♦A and East will take his three more ♠ tricks.

As much as you hate to put your contract in the hands of a 50% finesse chance, that is what you must do. Forget the ♦ suit and finesse East for the ♥K, trying for two extra tricks in ♥s.

East played very well to duck the second ♠, leaving his partner with a ♠ in case he could get the lead.

So you have to play well and stay away from ♦s.

Board 2
West Deals
N-S Vul

♠ 9 8 3 2
♥ 10 4
♦ 9 7 6 3
♣ K 10 5

♠ A K 5 4
♥ A 3 2
♦ Q J 10
♣ J 7 6



♠ 7
♥ K Q J 9 8 7 5
♦ A
♣ A 8 4 2

♠ Q J 10 6
♥ 6
♦ K 8 5 4 2
♣ Q 9 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	4♣	Pass
4♠	Pass	6♥	
All Pass			

6♥ by East
Lead: ♠Q

3

There would be nothing wrong with a transfer bid here, but probably no advantage either. What you really want to know is how many Aces partner has. So you ask him with a Gerber 4♣ bid.

Partner says 4♠ (2 Aces),

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Partner says 4♠ (2 Aces),

Looking at three possible ♣ losers you bid 6♥.

East plays 6♥. South leads the ♠Q. The first trick is easy; you win with dummy's ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 3 :: Total =

It can't do any good to ruff your fourth ♣ in dummy because you would have to lose two before that could happen. Of course one of your ♣s can be discarded on dummy's ♠K but what about the other two?

Suppose you win the ♠ and unblock the ♦A. Play ♥K, then to dummy's ♥A. Take one ♣ discard on the ♠K, then play the ♦Q and discard a second ♣.

It won't work. You would establish the ♦ for your last discard but you have no entry to it.

This will work. At trick 2 discard the ♦A on dummy's ♠K. Play the ♦Q and discard a ♣ when North doesn't cover. South will take the ♦K and attack ♣s but you are in control now. You win your ♣A, pull trumps, ending in dummy, and discard the remaining 2 ♣ losers on dummy's ♦ J 10.

This is called a Jettison play. You sacrifice your ♦A to unblock the suit for dummy's ♦ Q J 10.

If North held the ♦K the play would be slightly different; you would have to ruff when he covered. But the result would be the same.

Did you notice that you started with 3 ♣ losers and no ♦ loser, but you ended up losing 1 ♦ and no ♣s?

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 4 3 ♥ 9 5 ♦ A 7 3 ♣ K Q 9 5 3	
♠ Q J ♥ K Q 3 ♦ Q J 10 9 6 5 ♣ 7 6	N W E S	♠ 10 7 6 5 ♥ J 10 6 2 ♦ 8 ♣ A 8 4 2
	♠ A K 9 2 ♥ A 8 7 4 ♦ K 4 2 ♣ J 10	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
2♦	2NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♦Q

Partner's 2NT is the lebensohl convention. He requests that you bid 3♣ as a relay, which you do. Partner now bids 3NT.

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When partner bids 3NT AFTER the lebensohl 2NT, he is suggesting you play there, and he guarantees a stopper in their suit. You are happy to pass.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♦Q. West attacks in ♦s and you must make an immediate choice. Hold up, win in dummy, or win in your hand.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 5

First decide about what to do at trick #1. If you hold up and West plays another ♦, no harm will be done. But probably no good will be done either because West is likely to have 6 ♦s, leaving East with just a singleton anyway. But what if West pockets the one ♦ trick and switches to ♥s, a suit where you only have one stopper? Since that might turn out badly, you should **NOT** hold up.

As to which hand to win it in, that's easy. You need to preserve any dummy entries that you can so you win the first trick with your ♦K.

Now you establish some ♣ winners. You play the ♣J and both defenders play low.

You have to assume that defenders good enough to hold up their ♣A at the first opportunity will be good enough to do it on the second play also. But you can thwart them by next playing your ♣10 and overtaking with dummy's ♣Q. Even if they do hold up again you can continue with another ♣ from dummy to establish the suit while you still have the ♦A for an entry.

If you fail to overtake the second ♣ East will hold up the ♣A again.

Then you will lose all those ♣ tricks in dummy.

Board 4
South Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 10 9 6 4 ♥ 7 4 ♦ 9 6 3 ♣ Q 8 4 2	
♠ A Q 8 2 ♥ Q 10 9 ♦ K 10 4 ♣ A 10 6	N W E S	♠ 5 3 ♥ A J 8 6 2 ♦ 7 5 2 ♣ K J 9
	♠ K J 7 ♥ K 5 3 ♦ A Q J 8 ♣ 7 5 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♦
1NT	Pass	2♦	Pass
2♥	Pass	3NT	Pass
4♥			
All Pass			

4♥ by West
Lead: ♦9

The question is: Do you use Transfers after a 1NT OVERCALL? And in particular, can you bid the opponent's suit and have it mean a transfer instead of a cue-bid? This is something you and your partner need to agree on - as for me and my partner, we think 2♦ is a transfer. Partner replies 2♥.

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With 10 points you are between Invitational and Game-forcing. Which means you bid either 2NT or 3NT, whichever suits your fancy. Today let's say it is 3NT which partner converts to 4♥.

The contract would be 4♥ played by East.

West plays 4♥. North leads the ♦9. South wins the first trick with the ♦A, then plays ♦Q. You take your ♦K now, fearing that the next one could be ruffed by North.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 5

You hope South, who opened the bidding, (as North before the hands were rotated), will have the ♠K, which would reduce your losers to 4.

You win the second ♦ and play your ♥Q, taken by South with the ♥K. He cashes the ♦J, North following, then exits with a small ♥.

Win this trump and play one more, pulling South's last trump and ending in dummy. Play a ♠ to your ♠Q (which wins) then play ♠A and ruff a ♠ in dummy. South follows with the ♠7, ♠J and ♠K. Now you must try the ♣ finesse, but through whom?

Is it a 50-50 guess? Or is South more likely to have the ♣Q since he had the opening hand?

No, it is not a 50-50 guess. No, South doesn't have the ♣Q, North does. If you watched the cards that South has played you will realize he started with 3-3-4-3 distribution. You will also know that he started with 14 points outside the ♣ suit. If he had the ♣Q he would have a balanced 16 point hand and would have opened 1NT, not 1♦. So North has the ♣Q.

You can go through 100 hands and on 99 of them it won't matter if you pay attention to the cards played by the defenders or not.

But if you don't pay attention on all 100 of them you will miss the one time where your attention was needed.